

This was awarded to members of the French Expeditionary Force that served in Indochina, 75,000 of whom died. The force included French Legionnaires and colonial units in addition to regular troops.

Attacks step up

Overconfident in the wake of this stunning victory, in the following year, Giap launched offensives in the Red River Delta, threatening Hanoi and Haiphong. Commanded by General Jean de Lattre de Tassigny, the French repulsed the attacks with artillery and air bombardment, including the use of napalm—an incendiary bomb. As many as 10,000 Viet Minh were killed. However, a series of French operations in 1952 showed their inability to inflict serious damage on Viet Minh areas. They could not block supply routes from China or stop the guerrillas from invading neighboring Laos.



French column on the move

An American-supplied tank leads motorized infantry along a dike in the Red River Delta. Restricted to roads, French columns—*Groupements Mobiles*—were vulnerable to ambush by more flexible Viet Minh infantry.

“ There may be a **catastrophe**; there is **little chance of a miracle.**”

GENERAL DE LATTRE DE TASSIGNY, REPORT ON INDOCHINA SITUATION, SEPTEMBER 1951

US support

On the whole, the French Expeditionary Force fought well. It was a multinational army of professional soldiers in which the Foreign Legion and troops from France's African colonies figured prominently. From 1950 onward, the French received increasing military aid from the United States, which had identified the Viet Minh as a communist threat. They also expanded the Vietnamese National Army, serving the notionally independent state headed by Bao Dai. Its morale, however, was poor. In some areas, militias controlled by Catholic bishops or by the Cao Dai and Hoa Hao religious sects held off the Viet Minh.

By 1953, most of rural Vietnam was out of French control. Even in government-controlled areas guerrillas carried out terrorist attacks. With no prospect of victory, the French began to search for a way to withdraw from Indochina.